

THE REPRESENTATION OF GENDER ROLES IN PAKISTANI ENGLISH FICTION



By

Student Name: SUMNA NAZ

ID:20PLR11188

Department of English

Allama Iqbal Open University, Islamabad

2025

DECLARATION

I, **SUMNA NAZ**, ID: 20PLR11188 student of BS English at the Department of English, Allama Iqbal Open University do hereby solemnly declare that the thesis entitled “**The Representation of Gender Roles in Pakistani English Fiction**” submitted by me in partial fulfillment of BS English Program, is my original work, except where otherwise acknowledged in the text, and has not been submitted or published earlier and shall not, in future, be submitted by me for obtaining degree from this or any other university or institution. If found guilty, AIOU has the right to cancel my degree of BS English at any time.

Date: 22-07-2025

Signature: _____

Name: **SUMNA NAZ**

ID:20PLR11188

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Praise be to Allah, the Lord of the worlds, and peace and prayers be upon Mohamed His servant and messenger. Above all, I thank Allah, the Ever-Magnificent and Ever-Thankful, for His support and blessing. I'm confident this work wouldn't exist without His help. Our university allowed us to finish this task, which I am grateful for. I should thank certain persons who helped me throughout the research, especially my supervisor, who was always generous. I want to thank my dear friends for their support throughout my thesis. My family deserves special thanks for their unwavering support throughout my life, especially during my master's degree pursuits. I can finish this term paper because of their unconditional love and prayers.

DEDICATION

This thesis is dedicated to:

In the name of Allah, my Creator and Master, and Mohammed (May Allah bless and give him), who taught us the meaning of life, My homeland Pakistan, the warmest womb; the great martyrs and prisoners, the symbol of sacrifice; Allama Iqbal Open University, my second magnificent home; my great parents, who never stop giving in countless ways; my dearest sister, who leads me through the valley of darkness with hope and support; my beloved brothers, who stand by me when things look bleak; and my beloved friend, whom I can't force myself to stop loving. This research is dedicated to my family, the symbol of love and giving, my friends that support me, and all my heartfelt people.

ABSTRACT

This study explores the evolving gender roles in Pakistani English literature by looking at several works by Bapsi Sidhwa, Mohsin Hamid, Kamila Shamsie, Moni Mohsin, Daniyal Mueenuddin, and Mohammed Hanif. The study uses qualitative textual and discourse analysis to examine how these authors portray and challenge established gender norms in socio-cultural, religious, and political contexts. It does this by taking ideas from feminism, gender studies, and postcolonialism. The *Pakistani Bride* and *Ice-Candy-Man* are two early stories that show how women are treated badly and how they get by in societies when men are in charge. A lot of the time, they talk about honor, sexual assault, and quiet. Modern works like *Home Fire*, *The Reluctant Fundamentalist*, and *The Diary of a Social Butterfly*, on the other hand, reveal gender in more complicated and interrelated ways. In these stories, both men and women battle against and change their positions by being active, critical of institutionalized patriarchy, and taking charge of their own lives. The results suggest that Pakistani English writing is slowly changing from being a victim and passive to being empowered and complex. Women in stories often fight political, social, and ideological concerns even when they are hurting themselves. Men, on the other hand, are usually seen dealing with emotional issues and problems with their identity. The study also discussed about how satire, intersectionality, and narrative perspective might assist people in Pakistan come up with new ideas about what men and women should do. This study adds to the body of literary scholarship by showing how important English fiction is as a vehicle for questioning and changing the main ideas about gender in South Asian literature.

Key words: gender roles, Pakistani literature, cultural traditions, historical context etc.

CONTENTS

ABSTRACT	v
CHAPTER 1	1
INTRODUCTION	1
1.1 Background of the Study	1
1.2 Problem Statement	4
1.3 Research Objectives	4
1.4 Research Questions	4
1.5 Significance of the Research	4
CHAPTER 2	6
LITERATURE REVIEW	6
2.1 Theoretical Framework: Feminism, Gender Studies, Postcolonialism.....	6
2.2 Gender Roles in South Asian literature	8
2.3 Review of Key Works on Gender in Pakistani Fiction.....	11
2.4 Gaps in the Current Research	14
CHAPTER 3	15
RESEARCH METHODOLOGY	15
3.1 Research Approach	15
3.2 Research Design.....	15
3.3 Participants	15
3.4 Research Instrument.....	16
3.5 Data Collection.....	16
3.6 Data Analysis	16
CHAPTER 4	17
DATA ANALYSIS.....	17
4.1 Gender Roles in Early Pakistani English Fiction.....	17
4.2 Gender Roles in Contemporary Pakistani English Fiction.....	19
4.3 Challenging or Reinforcing Patriarchy	22
4.4 Intersectionality and Identity	24
CHAPTER 5	27
DISCUSSION, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS	27
5.1 Discussion.....	27
5.2 Conclusion	29

5.3	Recommendations	30
REFERENCES.....		31

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

The literary landscape of South Asia, and particularly Pakistan, when it comes to tradition and modernity, identity and power, and most importantly, gender and society. In Pakistani English fiction, how gender roles are shown reflects the country's deeper social, political, and cultural aspects. For a long time, literature has been an ideological tool that has shown, questioned, and sometimes reinforced gender stereotypes. As Pakistan tries to figure out its national identity in the face of globalization, religious orthodoxy, military, and economic disparity, the roles of men and women in society are always changing. Especially in the last forty years, this new concept has made its way into the fiction written by Pakistanis in English. These works not only show how gender injustice and inequality really are, but they also give a voice to the people who are left out and fight back. So, examines gender roles are shown in Pakistani English fiction is a strong way to learn about the tensions, inconsistencies, and changes that are happening in Pakistani culture.

1.1 Background of the Study

Gender in literature isn't just about male and female characters; it's also about the roles, expectations, performances, and power structures that go along with these groups. Judith Butler's (1990) theory of gender performativity says that gender is not something you are born with, but something you do over and over again based on what society expects of you. Using this approach to examines literature, especially fiction, can help us figure out how characters play or break gender norms in their social circumstances. In Pakistani fiction, these kinds of performances are shaped by a number of themes that overlap, such as religion, culture, class, and the legacy of colonialism. In the past, women in Pakistan were mostly limited to the home, while men mostly ran public life. In Pakistani stories, these oppositions—private vs. public, submissive vs. authoritative—have been important for a long time (Shaheed, 2002). But over time, especially with the rise of feminist movements, education, and digital media, these lines have become less clear in both society and literature.

As English literature has become more popular in Pakistan, there has also been a global interest in South Asian points of view, especially those that deal with identity, migration, religion, and gender. Bapsi Sidhwa, Kamila Shamsie, Mohsin Hamid, Moni Mohsin, Mohammed Hanif, and Fatima Bhutto are just a few of the writers who have gained

international fame for both their writing styles and their sophisticated depictions of gender relations. These writers show a range of gendered experiences, from upper-class city women dealing with their identities and desires to working-class characters trying to stay alive in patriarchal systems. Bapsi Sidhwa's *The Pakistani Bride* (1983) is one example. It portrays the story of a young girl who is compelled to marry and exposes how bad gender prejudice can be. It also illustrates how powerful women can be. Kamila Shamsie's *Burnt Shadows* (2009) and *Home Fire* (2017) explore more closely at how gender influences terrorism, geopolitics, and the diaspora. They represent powerful women who fight against the limits that tradition and modernity set on them. Hamid's 2007 novel *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* features a male character who is struggling with identity, love, and nationalism in the world after 9/11. This gives us an introspective look into South Asian masculinity in crisis (Boehmer, 2009). Even though these stories are set in specific places, they deal with global issues of gender, power, and representation.

Colonialism brought forth not simply a new governmental system, but also new ideas and rules about gender, especially through the lens of Victorian morality and orientalist ideas. In her important essay "Can the Subaltern Speak?" Spivak (1988) said that colonial discourse generally showed colonized women as passive individuals who needed to be saved. This image is still common in Western depictions of South Asian women. Pakistani English fiction is a place where people fight against both local patriarchy and Western essentialism. By taking back control of the story, female characters (and their authors) fight orientalist clichés and show that their identities are more complicated than simple binaries.

Also, the politics of language and class in Pakistan adds to the complexity of gendered stories. Because of colonialism, English is generally linked to power, education, and elitism. Because of this, many English-language authors write about educated, city-dwelling individuals whose lives may be very different from those of rural or lower-class characters. This presents both chances and problems. For example, English fiction can reach people all over the world and challenge common ideas about Pakistan. On the other hand, it could leave out the voices of marginalized groups whose experiences aren't recorded in literary canon (Rahman, 1996). This disparity between classes and languages is a sign of bigger problems in Pakistani culture, where poverty and lack of education sometimes make gender inequality worse.

Kimberlé Crenshaw (1989) came up with the term "intersectionality" to describe how diverse components of identity, such race, class, religion, and gender, combine together to

generate unique experiences of oppression. Modern Pakistani fiction often looks at gender through this lens. Fatima Bhutto's book *The Shadow of the Crescent Moon* (2013) is one example of how Pashtun women in a war zone had to contend with violence from both religious fanatics and the military. These kinds of stories do more than just highlight how bad things are; they also show how hard it is to deal with gender-based oppression in Pakistan. Moni Mohsin's satirical books, especially *The Diary of a Social Butterfly*, also employ humor to make fun of elitist gender stereotypes, materialism, and performative feminism. These various pictures go against the perception that all South Asian women are the same in popular talk.

Pakistani fiction shows more than just individual characters; it also shows larger gender discourses that are molded by national ideologies, religious interpretations, and how the media portrays them. When the state tries to define gender norms, especially when there are military regimes in power, they often use idealized pictures of the submissive, humble lady as a symbol of national honor. During General Zia-ul-Haq's Islamization (1977–1988), policies and cultural narratives made patriarchal interpretations of Islamic law official, limited women's rights, and enforced moral policing (Jalal, 1991). Fictional stories that are made in response to this kind of authoritarianism, whether it's obvious or not, show the conflict between gender roles that the state forces on people and people's freedom to choose. For instance, the women in Sidhwa's and Shamsie's novels often have to deal with laws and social norms that try to regulate their bodies and choices. This is a criticism of gendered state power.

The global war on terror, the rise of religious extremism, and the ensuing securitization of Pakistani society has all had an effect on how gender is represented in literature. Stories that take place after 9/11 generally deal with issues of surveillance, identity, veiling, and belonging, especially for Muslim women. But a lot of Pakistani writers don't like how veiled women are often shown as downtrodden. Instead, they provide different meanings to veiling, such as a sign of faith, identity, resistance, or choice. This goes against Western feminist views that see hijab as a sign of oppression (Mahmood, 2005). This variety in representation is a big step forward for Pakistani English fiction, as gender is shown not as a fixed category but as a changing and contested space.

1.2 Problem Statement

There is a lot more Pakistani English fiction out there, and it is garnering more and more attention around the world. However, there is still a major gap in academic studies on how gender roles are shown in this literature. A lot of the negative reviews of Pakistani fiction have been about terrorism, identity, postcolonialism, and the diaspora. It doesn't usually discuss about how stories show, question, and modify gender roles. Because of this lack of attention, it's tougher for us to understand how literature reflects and shapes gendered reality in Pakistan's social and cultural milieu. In Pakistan, traditional ideas about what it means to be a man or a woman, which come from patriarchal standards, religious interpretations, and colonial legacies, continue to shape how people see themselves. But modern fiction often goes against these assumptions by showing people that break, oppose, or negotiate their gender roles in complicated ways. We need to look closely at how these fictional characters deal with and react to real-world gender issues, especially now that globalization, urbanization, and feminist movements are on the rise.

1.3 Research Objectives

- To carefully explore the gender roles that are depicted in some modern Pakistani English novels.
- To examine how stories in literature support established gender roles in the religious, social, and cultural setting of Pakistan.

1.4 Research Questions

1. How do certain modern Pakistani English novels show gender roles?
2. In what ways do these literary works question or support the patriarchal norms and expectations that exist in Pakistani society?

1.5 Significance of the Research

This study is important for literary criticism, gender studies, and South Asian cultural studies since it goes into great detail about how gender roles are shown in Pakistani English fiction. Literature is a strong cultural tool that may challenge social norms, make people think critically, and spark change. This study looks at how gender roles are made, challenged, or broken down in modern novels. It shows how authors subtly reflect ongoing discussions in Pakistani culture about identity, power, and resistance. In this way, it helps connect the gap between how gender is represented in literature and how it really is in life. It shows how

fiction can both reflect and criticize the gendered realities of Pakistan's diverse cultural terrain.

The study also gives worldwide feminist literary criticism a much-needed South Asian point of view. Most of the time, these criticisms have been focused on Western stories and concepts. This study looks into the views and experiences of Pakistani women, which goes against the stereotype that all Muslim or South Asian women are either oppressed victims or interesting people. Instead, it gives a more nuanced and context-sensitive picture of gender identities. It also reveals how men are limited by and resistant to cultural standards, which makes the conversation about gender more open. The results of this study can benefit teachers, literary scholars, gender activists, and legislators who seek to make cultural and educational environments in Pakistan and other locations more aware of gender issues.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Theoretical Framework: Feminism, Gender Studies, Postcolonialism

Gender roles, especially how literature critiques societal and cultural concepts of man and woman, are examined through feminist theory. Feminism seeks to dismantle barriers to gender equality. Literary studies examine women's lives, voices, and experiences. Simone de Beauvoir's 1949 novel *The Second Sex* argued that "one is not born, but rather becomes, a woman." This novel showed that society defines femininity, not biology. This idea showed us how literature reinforces and breaks gender preconceptions.

Feminist literary theory enables us assess how Pakistani English fiction portrays female characters as passive victims, powerful survivors, or active change agents. It makes individuals consider louder or quieter voices. Feminist theorists like Elaine Showalter (1977), Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar (1979), and others value a female literary tradition created by and about women. Women writers like Bapsi Sidhwa, Kamila Shamsie, and Fatima Bhutto in Pakistani fiction challenge male-dominated narrative traditions and offer new perspectives on feminism, body politics, and resistance.

Feminist theory emphasizes the distinction between public and private life, which is common in South Asian literature because women are rarely seen in public. In Sidhwa's *The Pakistani Bride* and Shamsie's *Salt and Saffron*, women fight for supremacy at home through quiet, subversion, or open revolt. These examples reflect bell hooks' (1984) thesis that "patriarchy has no gender," meaning men and women can uphold patriarchal rules. Thus, feminist theory is needed to study how literature sustains or challenges gendered power structures.

Feminist philosophy focuses on women's issues, whereas gender studies explore how society creates femininity and masculinity. Judith Butler's (1990) gender performativity theory is crucial to gender studies. It claims that gender is a set of stereotyped activities reinforced by cultural norms and expectations. According to this idea, literature is where characters play their gender roles by following or breaking the rules. This approach is useful for studying Pakistani male characters experiencing masculinity problems, disillusionment, or vulnerability. In Mohsin Hamid's *Moth Smoke*, the main character's social and moral decline

may reflect metropolitan Pakistan's fragile hegemonic masculinity. The Reluctant Fundamentalist's main character has conflicted feelings between Western modernity and Eastern heritage because of his masculinity, which is shaped by honor, patriotism, and rejection. These descriptions make it tougher to regard men as patriarchy's cause and show their struggles in patriarchy.

Kimberlé Crenshaw (1989) coined "intersectionality," a gender studies term. It examines gender relations with class, race, religion, and place. This notion helps examine the numerous oppressions underprivileged protagonists in Pakistani fiction face. In Fatima Bhutto's *The Shadow of the Crescent Moon*, women face patriarchy and militaristic cruelty. This shows how gender and geopolitics may worsen things. Moni Mohsin's satire in *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* exposes elite, metropolitan feminism as shallow and detached from actual life. These examples demonstrate that gendered experiences in Pakistani fiction vary by environment and person.

Gender studies also help us understand non-normative gender identities and sexualities, which is a topic that hasn't been explored much in Pakistani English fiction yet because of cultural and legal barriers. However, newer narratives have begun to touch on themes of queer identity and sexual flexibility, albeit gingerly. These new representations go against the heterosexual matrix and make it possible for South Asian literature to have more open-minded readings of gender and sexuality. Because of Pakistan's colonial history and what happened after it, postcolonial theory is important for understanding how colonialism and imperial discourse affect and shape gender norms (Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, 1988).

Edward Said (1978) and Homi Bhabha (1994) are some postcolonial theorists who have looked at how colonial stories made the "Orient" seem illogical, backward, and feminine, while making the West seem rational, progressive, and masculine. This dichotomy not only made colonial rule seem right, but it also had a big impact on how people thought about gender in colonized nations.

"Can the subaltern speak?" is a famous question by Spivak (1988) that is very pertinent when examining Pakistani fiction provides women and other oppressed groups a voice. Colonial and nationalist ideologies often silence women or use their subjection for political gain, she says. Pakistani literature depicts women as trapped between Islamic conservatism and Western liberalism, neither of which recognizes their agency or lived realities. Postcolonial readings of imperialism, nationalism, and migration's effects on men

and women are encouraged by fiction like Shamsie's *Burnt Shadows* and Sidhwa's *Ice-Candy-Man*.

Language can also have power in postcolonial theory. Pakistan uses English to empower and exclude because it was the colonizers' language. English-language authors write for a global audience. This raises crucial representation, authenticity, and accessibility issues. Tariq Rahman (1996) claims that English in Pakistani literature creates a language hierarchy that excludes vernacular voices and experiences. Rural, working-class women, who often can't learn English, are usually excluded from English-language novels, making this issue even more gendered. Therefore, postcolonial theory makes it harder to determine who, by whom, and for whom gendered experiences are told.

Homi Bhabha's (1994) hybridity concept can also be used to study how Pakistani fiction characters handle several cultural identities. Diaspora women face various gender roles, attire, marriage, and independence demands from their families, communities, and selves. The "in-between" portions of identity allow resistance and change. Shamsie's *Home Fire*'s protagonist must choose between British liberalism and Pakistani conservatism in a complex social and political landscape. These examples indicate that postcoloniality is a live force that transforms gender identities in interesting ways.

2.2 Gender Roles in South Asian literature

In the past, South Asian literature has shown how gender roles are shaped by the region's complicated social systems, religious beliefs, colonial history, and changing political situations. Gendered depictions have both mirrored and challenged the roles that society expects men and women to play in everything from classical epics like the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana* to modern South Asian English fiction. Traditional literature generally reinforced patriarchal standards by glorifying male heroics and feminine virtue. In contrast, modern and postcolonial stories are more likely to focus on themes of resistance, identity, and gender subversion. In this light, the way gender is shown in Pakistani English fiction is part of a larger South Asian literary tradition that deals with the interconnections of gender, class, religion, and nationalism.

In the past, South Asian literature has shown women in strict roles, such the Sati-Savitri model, which shows women as loyal, docile, self-sacrificing wives or mothers. Tharu and Lalita (1991) say in their important novel *Women Writing in India* that these women were moral role models in a society that was very patriarchal. Women like Sita in the

Ramayana and Draupadi in the Mahabharata are admired for their morality, loyalty, and strength, yet they can also be humiliated, abandoned, or turned into objects. In this culture, women's worth is based on their chastity, obedience, and submission to male authority. These epics have religious and moral meaning, but modern feminist retellings have also looked at them in new ways and challenged them in order to give women back their voice and power.

The colonial encounter substantially shaped gender ideas in South Asian literature. During the British Raj, gender became a symbolic battleground between tradition and modernity. Indian nationalists and colonial officials told different stories about what it meant to be a woman. Chatterjee (1993) says that nationalist theorists typically saw women as the protectors of cultural purity. They put them in the home and pushed for Western education and modernization for men. This gendered division of labor was shown in novels that praised the "new woman" as being educated and morally good, but also as being domesticated and spiritually superior. For example, Bengali novels from the 1800s, like Bankim Chandra Chatterjee's *Anandamath*, showed women as both national emblems and moral anchors for the country. But these images didn't often question the basic patriarchal system that kept women in supportive, reproductive duties.

As modern South Asian fiction became popular in the 20th century, especially after independence, gender roles became murkier. Urdu writer Ismat Chughtai, Bengali writer Mahasweta Devi, and English writer Kamala Das freely discussed women's sexuality, marriage oppression, and class exploitation, defying literary conventions. Lihaaf (1942), Chughtai's controversial short story, depicted same-sex yearning in a home where women couldn't show their faces. These literary works paved the way for succeeding writers to explore gender identity in a rapidly changing and politically unstable environment.

South Asia embraced feminist literary critique in the 1980s and 1990s, along with the global feminist movement and scholars like Susie Tharu, Meenakshi Mukherjee, and Sara Suleri. These scholars noted that South Asian literature contained patriarchal principles but also rebelled. According to Meenakshi Mukherjee (1993), regional female characters often use "silent rebellion" to challenge repressive governments through silence, subtext, or maternal authority. These personalities don't necessarily embody Western feminist values. Instead, they demonstrate how culture, caste, religion, and family dynamics shape resistance.

Intersectionality, established by Kimberlé Crenshaw in 1989, is a prominent theme in South Asian literature. It examines how gender, caste, class, and religion oppression affect

people's lives. Caste still affects gender roles in India, and Dalit women are discriminated against. Bama (Karukku, 1992) and Urmila Pawar (*The Weave of My Life*, 2008) write honest accounts of caste, class, and gender. Their experiences demonstrate how difficult it is for marginalized women to gain education, respect, and equality. These writers generally write in Tamil and Marathi, but their translated works contribute to South Asian gender discourse.

In the same way, the connection of gender with war and political violence has affected how women and men are portrayed in Bangladeshi and Sri Lankan literature. In Tahmima Anam's *A Golden Age* (2007), which takes place during the Bangladesh Liberation War, the main character Rehana has to deal with being a mother, a nationalist, and a survivor. Her moral problems and quiet strength go against the idea that South Asian women are weak victims of history. Sri Lankan literature, especially those from after the civil war, shows gender in comparable ways when it comes to trauma and resistance. Shyam Selvadurai's *Funny Boy* (1994) is about both homosexuality and ethnic conflict. It shows how gender identity is affected by changes in culture and nationality.

In South Asian diaspora literature, gender roles are made even more problematic by problems of assimilation, cultural preservation, and racialization. Jhumpa Lahiri (*Interpreter of Maladies*, 1999) and Meera Syal (*Anita and Me*, 1996) are two authors who write about the cultural and generational issues that South Asian women face in the West. In these stories, first-generation immigrant women are generally seen as carrying on traditions and being responsible for protecting cultural honor. Their children, especially girls, must balance independence and cultural loyalty. Gender is a place where characters struggle to fit in and feel alone in unfamiliar social contexts.

Pakistani English literature, part of the South Asian literary tradition, has shaped gender roles discussions, especially via women's stories. Bapsi Sidhwa's *The Bride* (1983) depicts tribal society's mistreatment of women and their strength and resourcefulness. Kamila Shamsie's *Burnt Shadows* (2009) and *Home Fire* (2017) feature female heroines who challenge gender norms in migration, terrorism, and transnational identity. These stories demonstrate that gender in South Asian literature varies with history and politics.

Recent South Asian literary criticism has examined masculinity. Male characters were traditionally harsh, authoritative, and protective. They are now more commonly presented as emotionally unstable, vulnerable, or having an identity crisis. In Mohsin Hamid's *Moth*

Smoke and Arundhati Roy's *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* (2017), masculine characters defy masculinity and social norms. These pieces examine toxic masculinity and its constraints on males to broaden the gender discourse beyond women's issues.

LGBTQ+ stories are becoming more common in South Asian literature, despite social stigma and legal prohibitions in some countries. R. Raj Rao's *The Boyfriend* (2003) and Anirban Das's *Towards a Politics of the (Im)possible* (2010) explore same-sex desire and queer identification in South Asian cities. These writings challenge gender stereotypes and offer new perspectives on identity and proximity. Even while these kinds of depictions are still rare and often controversial, they show that the literary world is changing to include more various gender expressions.

Digital platforms and social media have also affected South Asian gender-aware literature. Online zines, blogs, and literary periodicals allow marginalized voices to share gender-challenging stories. This digital democratization of literary expression works well with the formal publishing sector and gives readers more stories to choose from. It also highlights how feminist activism and gender justice movements are altering South Asian culture and language.

2.3 Review of Key Works on Gender in Pakistani Fiction

Many people think of Bapsi Sidhwa as a pioneer in Pakistani English fiction, notably for putting women's views front and center in Pakistan's patriarchal society. *The Pakistani Bride* (1983) is a novel based on a true event about a young orphan girl named Zaitoon who is married off to a tribal man. The novel discussed about violence against women, honor culture, and how rigid tribal traditions keep women from having a say in things. Zaitoon's path to freedom, even though it was full of pain, is a symbol of the fight against deeply rooted patriarchal conventions (Afzal-Khan, 1993). Sidhwa's *Ice-Candy-Man* (1988), which was published around the world as *Cracking India*, also gives a powerful examines gender-based violence during the Partition of India. The story is told from the point of view of a little girl, and it shows how community conflict makes women more vulnerable and turns them into puppets in nationalist and religious agendas. Boehmer (2005) and other critics say that Sidhwa's novels change the way history is told by putting women's trauma and testimony at the heart of the story.

Kamila Shamsie's writing is a big step forward for Pakistani fiction, especially because of her complicated female characters and locations that cross national borders.

Shamsie's 2009 novel *Burnt Shadows* is about Hiroko Tanaka, a Japanese woman whose life is affected by the political unrest in Pakistan, India, Afghanistan, and the U.S. The novel looks at how women experience conflict, migration, and nationalism in ways that are distinct from men, often being both witnesses and victims of history. Shamsie's portrayal of women's resilience, grief, and survival across cultural boundaries changes the way we think about global femininity (Alam, 2012). In a modern retelling of Sophocles' *Antigone*, Shamsie tells the story of Aneeka and Isma, two British-Pakistani sisters, as they deal with themes of faith, freedom, and government spying. The novel discussed on how counter-terrorism and Islamophobia in the West are gendered, with Muslim women being either very visible or not at all, depending on the political and social situation (Shariff, 2019). Shamsie's feminist perspective is quiet but strong, showing that the women in her novels are never just victims; they are strategic agents trying to figure out how to deal with competing identities.

Mohsin Hamid's work on gender is especially important since he questions what it means to be a man and how men examine women. In the 2000 movie *Moth Smoke*, the main character, Darashikoh Shehzad, is a Pakistani man who is estranged, disenfranchised, and ethically ambiguous. Hamid breaks down the idea of the stable, sensible guy by showing how Daru's intense love for a married woman leads him to drugs and criminality. *Moth Smoke* confronts toxic masculinity by showing men being vulnerable and having emotional breakdowns, which breaks down traditional gender roles, as Jajja (2013) points out. In *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* (2007), Hamid makes masculinity even more complicated by connecting it to nationalism, race, and politics after 9/11. Changez, the main character, struggles with his Pakistani identity as he moves through elite American places, sexual connections, and political betrayal. His manhood doesn't come from being in charge; it comes from thinking about his feelings, grief, and the meaning of life (Gohar, 2009). These stories that focus on men provide us a chance to think about what it means to be a man in a postcolonial and globalized Pakistan.

The Shadow of the Crescent Moon (2013) by Fatima Bhutto is about how men and women view things differently in a conflict-ridden part of Pakistan's tribal belt. The story takes place in a tiny hamlet where military activities and religious extremism are going on. It follows three brothers and two ladies over the course of one morning. Bhutto focuses on the quiet fortitude and emotional depth of female characters like Samarra and Mina, whose lives are affected by both personal grief and the larger machinery of war. The novel makes it clear that women in these situations are not only victims; they are also political players, caregivers,

and peacemakers (Ali, 2016). Bhutto's writing stands out because it discussed about how gender affects conflict, displacement, and religious dogma, which are topics that are generally ignored in popular Pakistani fiction.

Moni Mohsin's writing, especially *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* (2008), utilizes satire and humor to make fun of how shallowly privileged Pakistani culture deals with gender and politics. Mohsin's main character, a self-absorbed socialite, speaks for her. Through her, Mohsin criticizes the commercialization of feminism, performative liberalism, and gender hypocrisy among urban elites. People often say that Mohsin's writing is only light reading, but scholars like Shamsie (2010) have pointed out how funny it can be to show how class and gender don't always match up in Pakistani society. The difference between the main character's lightheartedness and the serious social and political issues going on in the background is a novel way of telling a story that goes against traditional ways of critiquing gender.

Another important voice in modern Pakistani fiction is Mohammed Hanif, who uses dark humor and political satire to talk about gender and power. Hanif uses General Zia-ul-Haq's rule as a lens to criticize militarism, religious fundamentalism, and toxic masculinity in *A Case of Exploding Mangoes* (2008). Even though female characters aren't the main focus, they are portrayed to be under surveillance, sexual suspicion, and institutional oppression, which is similar to the effects of authoritarian control on women in general. His next novel, *Our Lady of Alice Bhatti* (2011), is about a Christian nurse and how gender, religion, and class affect people in Karachi's hospitals and slums. Alice is a Christian woman from a lower-class background who faces a lot of discrimination. She fights back with sarcasm, strength, and her faith. Akhtar (2015) and other scholars say that Alice's persona represents subaltern resistance in a culture where gender and religion often mix.

Several critical studies have also helped academics comprehend how gender is portrayed in Pakistani fiction, along with these made-up works. Afzal-Khan's *Cultural Imperialism and the Indo-English Novel* (1993) is a feminist postcolonial examines South Asian literature, featuring stories from Pakistan. Her work focuses on how women writers take back control of the story and how female characters often depict places where cultures clash. Shirin Zubair's (2006) study of feminist writing in Pakistani English fiction also shows how more and more female writers are pushing back against patriarchal ideas while also dealing with cultural and religious demands. Zubair says that literature gives us a "counter-discourse" that sees women not as victims but as active agents who make meaning.

There is a lot of research going on about queer theory and how it is slowly becoming more common in Pakistani fiction. Pakistan is still socially strict, although recent novels have started to talk about sexualities that aren't considered normal. For example, Shandana Minhas's *Tunnel Vision* (2007) incorporates subtle references to women's desire that go against what most people think about women and men. Anthologies like *And the World Changed* (ed. Muneeza Shamsie, 2005) also have short stories that deal with issues of bodily autonomy, gender fluidity, and sexual agency. Even though they are still on the fringe, these stories show that the literary world is steadily becoming more open to gender diversity.

2.4 Gaps in the Current Research

Rising Pakistani English fiction has garnered critical attention in recent years. Scope, intersectionality, and inclusivity deficiencies remain in gender representation scholarship. Much research has concentrated on famous female authors like Bapsi Sidhwa and Kamila Shamsie. They intrigue scholars because to their feminist ideas and international fame. This technique occasionally excludes lesser-known or emerging writers who write complexly and distinctively about gender, notably rural, lower-class, or religious minority places (Zubair, 2006). Because of this, Pakistani literature rarely depicts women's diverse experiences. Also, most of the time, contemporary research focuses too much on women's oppression and suffering, leaving out more diverse depictions of women's power, strength, and rebellion (Afzal-Khan, 1993).

This restricted focus could reinforce oversimplified preconceptions and doesn't take into consideration the many ways women deal with patriarchy. In the same way, the way masculinity is shown in Pakistani fiction has not gotten much attention, even though modern writers like Mohsin Hamid and Mohammed Hanif are writing about changing ideas of manhood, male vulnerability, and toxic masculinity more and more (Jajja, 2013). Another big problem is that intersectional and queer theoretical frameworks aren't used enough to look into Pakistani fiction. A lot of research has been done using Western feminist and postcolonial theories, but not many have looked closely at how gender interacts with caste, sect, ethnicity, and sexual orientation in Pakistan (Crenshaw, 1989; Zubair, 2006). Also, there isn't enough research on non-heteronormative identities, partially because of social and cultural taboos and partly because there isn't enough academic interest.

CHAPTER 3

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Approach

The study uses qualitative research, which is the best way to examine how literary novels use language, themes, and narrative techniques to build, question, or reinforce gender roles. Qualitative research lets the researcher look closely at the chosen novels and interpret them, focusing on the complex issues of gendered identities, power relations, and socio-cultural commentary that are present in the works. The research doesn't test a hypothesis; instead, it tries to get deep, complex insights by thoroughly reading and analyzing fiction through feminist, gender, and postcolonial theoretical lenses.

3.2 Research Design

The study design is based on textual and discourse analysis, which lets you read literary texts in a way that takes into account their meaning and context. Discourse analysis looks at how language shows power dynamics, beliefs, and social conventions, while textual analysis looks at how character depiction, story structure, conversation, and symbols shape gender. The study looks closely at six important Pakistani English writers whose works show a range of styles, themes, and points of view on gender. The selected texts include:

- *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* by Mohsin Hamid
- *Salt and Saffron*, *Kartography*, and *Home Fire* by Kamila Shamsie
- *The Pakistani Bride* and *Ice-Candy-Man* by Bapsi Sidhwa
- *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders* by Daniyal Mueenuddin
- *A Case of Exploding Mangoes* by Mohammed Hanif
- *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* by Moni Mohsin

3.3 Participants

In qualitative textual study, the "participants" are not people but the literary works that were chosen. This study looks at eight novels and short story collections by well-known

Pakistani authors who write in English. These works were chosen on purpose because they deal with themes including gender, class, power, identity, and societal criticism. They use several types of storytelling, such as satire, realism, political allegory, and postmodern fragmentation, and they show both men's and women's points of view on gender roles. The chosen works cover a wide range of historical periods, from Partition and military dictatorship to globalization after 9/11. This makes sure that there is a wide range of contexts for gender study.

3.4 Research Instrument

The main research tool in this study is the researcher as reader and interpreter, who uses a mix of close reading techniques, theoretical frameworks, and critical reflection. We create an interpretative reading guide based on feminist literary criticism, gender theory (Butler, 1990; Crenshaw, 1989), and postcolonial discourse (Said, 1978; Spivak, 1988) to get information from the works. Analytical categories including portrayals of masculinity and femininity, agency and oppression, intersectionality, domestic vs. public locations, and the use of satire or irony to criticize gender roles help find key themes and patterns.

3.5 Data Collection

Data collection means carefully reading each chosen literary novel with an emphasis on themes linked to gender, narrative techniques, character development, and commentary on social and political issues. For each novel or story, notes, comments, and thematic summaries are put together. Quotes and extracts that show how gender roles, character roles, language patterns, or ideological framing work are recorded and classified for study. This method is iterative and reflexive, which means that as patterns and conflicts show up in the texts, they can be interpreted and understood in different ways.

3.6 Data Analysis

The process of analyzing data is based on discourse analysis and thematic coding. We examine each text to see how it discussed about, supports, or questions gender roles in the story. The focus of the analysis is on how language is used, metaphors, symbols, dialogue, and character arcs. Examine novels like *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* and *Kartography* to see how male characters deal with their dual identities and performances of masculinity. We also examine novels like *The Pakistani Bride* and *Ice-Candy-Man* to see how female characters deal with patriarchy, violence, and cultural standards. *The Diary of a Social*

Butterfly by Moni Mohsin is looked at for its humorous criticism of elite gender roles and performative feminism. Using feminist and postcolonial theory, the results are looked at through the lens of the social and political situations that affect how gender is shown in modern Pakistani fiction.

CHAPTER 4

DATA ANALYSIS

4.1 Gender Roles in Early Pakistani English Fiction

Early Pakistani English writing, especially Bapsi Sidhwa's, strongly criticizes South Asian patriarchal gender stereotypes. Through intricate storylines and well-developed characters, Sidhwa examines women's constraints and the social mechanisms that perpetuate gender inequity. Her works *The Pakistani Bride* (1983) and *Ice-Candy-Man* (1988) depict women living in a complex world governed by men, stuck between submission and resistance. These works demonstrate women's oppression and suggest their strength and subversion, which is significant for Pakistani English literary discourse on gender.

Sidhwa's novel *The Pakistani Bride* is about Zaitoon, an orphan who is adopted by a retired army officer named Qasim. He then marries her off to a tribal guy from the Kohistani hills. The novel explores the subjects of forced marriage, honor, women's independence, and cultural rigidity, all of which are part of the gendered structures of tribal and urban Pakistani society. From the start, Zaitoon is shown as a girl who has no control over her life and whose future is decided by men. Qasim loves her, but in the end, he sees her as a way to fulfill his tribal duties: "*The idea of marrying her into the hills had remained latent in his mind... like the obligation he owed the mountains*" (Sidhwa, 1983, p. 19).

This patriarchal deal, in which a woman is a token to be traded for honor and tradition, is a lot like what many South Asian women go through in real life. The tribal group that Zaitoon is placed to has strict gender roles. Wives are expected to be obedient, submissive, and invisible. Her spouse, Sakhi, is a harsh enforcer of these rules, expecting to be able to control her body and movements completely. Zaitoon's struggle to get away from this violence is a sign of a larger feminist uprising. Sidhwa writes that as she runs away into

the mountains, *"She ran with all the strength her will and legs could muster, her eyes wild, her lips dry, and her dupatta flapping like a banner"* (Sidhwa, 1983, p. 161). The dupatta, which is usually a sign of humility and submission, is now seen as a sign of defiance, which shows that gender symbolism is changing.

Even though Zaitoon is in pain, her struggle toward freedom goes against the usual story of women being submissive. Not as a failure, but as a brave choice to leave violence behind. Afzal-Khan (1993) says, *"Zaitoon's flight from her tribal husband is an act of revolutionary defiance against a culture that equates femininity with silence and suffering"* (p. 98). The novel criticizes not only tribal sexism but also how cities help keep patriarchal traditions in place, giving a full picture of how gender inequality affects people in Pakistan.

Ice-Candy-Man (1988), on the other hand, looks at the effects of political and religious turmoil on women via the perspective of communal violence. It takes place during the Partition of India in 1947. Lenny, a young Parsi girl with polio, tells the story of how women's bodies become battlegrounds during times of societal turmoil. Ayah, a beautiful Hindu nanny, is the main female character. Men of all religions love her, but her sexuality becomes dangerous in a society that is falling apart because of animosity between groups. Ayah is finally kidnapped by the main character, *Ice-Candy-Man*, who goes from being a sweet admirer to a symbol of violent, possessive masculinity as political tensions increase. The story shows Ayah as both a victim and a symbol of the gender-based violence that happened during Partition. The terror is shown in a tragic way when she is kidnapped and forced into prostitution: *"He has taken her to the Kotha—she's a dancing girl now"* (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 188). Her change from caregiver to object represents the destiny of many women during Partition, who were kidnapped, raped, or forced to convert. Lenny's helpless comment, *"My Ayah." My beautiful, beautiful Ayah. Gone. Because of the guys. "All the men"* (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 190)—is a child's criticism of both nationalism and sexism.

Ayah's story also shows how women are treated like property during times of communal violence, when males regard women's bodies as things to claim in the interest of honor or revenge. Sidhwa doesn't make Ayah's anguish seem beautiful; instead, she shows how the system of violence lets it happen. In a world where men are in charge, *Ice-Candy-Man* justifies his conduct by saying, *"What else could I do?" "She's mine now!"* (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 191). This possessive reasoning shows how women are treated like objects when gender norms are based on power, control, and honor.

Even while there is a lot of brutality in *Ice-Candy-Man*, there are also small signs of resistance. Lenny's mother and godmother are strong women who fight together to get Ayah back with her family. This shows how women support each other. Godmother is shown to be morally upright and assertive, even standing up to strong individuals to protect Ayah, saying, "*You will bring her to me, Ice-Candy-Man—or I will have you thrown in jail*" (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 195). These characters go against the old idea of passive femininity versus aggressive masculinity by showing different ways of being a woman that are centered on justice, compassion, and action.

Sidhwa's early literature also shows how women typically show their power in non-verbal, symbolic ways. These moments, like Zaitoon's journey across the mountains or Ayah's silent endurance, go against the idea that female resistance has to be loud or public. Mukherjee (1993) says that "*In Sidhwa's novels, even silence becomes a form of protest, a way of withholding complicity from systems that seek to define women through male desires*" (p. 122).

Sidhwa also makes a gendered geography, where space is partitioned and controlled by men. In *The Pakistani Bride*, the tribal village is a little, closed-off place where people watch one other, while the mountains are a place of freedom and peril. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, the same thing happens: the female characters are generally stuck at home, while the public area becomes a place where men control politics, violence, and religious beliefs. When women walk across these lines, whether on purpose or not, it breaks the spatial logic of patriarchy and shows how weak it is.

In both novels, male characters are seen as both oppressors and products of their surroundings. People like Qasim and *Ice-Candy-Man* are not just bad guys; their actions are molded by cultural ideas of honor, masculinity, and tradition. Sidhwa's complex picture of male psyche shows how patriarchal norms keep violence and emotional repression going. Jajja (2013) says that "*Early Pakistani fiction rarely questioned male vulnerability, but Sidhwa's work opens up space for questioning the emotional costs of masculinity as well*" (p. 36).

4.2 Gender Roles in Contemporary Pakistani English Fiction

In modern Pakistani English fiction, gender roles are no longer limited to traditional binaries or stereotypes. Kamila Shamsie's *Home Fire* (2017) is an openly political examination of gender roles, especially in the Muslim diaspora. Aneeka, a young British-Pakistani woman,

wants justice and respect for her brother, who is suspected of terrorism and not allowed to be buried. She goes against both British spying and Muslim fundamentalism. "It's clear that she won't stay quiet: *"I'm going to find my brother's body and bury him with my own hands if I have to"* (Shamsie, 2017, p. 231). Shamsie uses Aneeka to reject the idea of docile Muslim femininity and instead shows how women may be powerful within and against patriarchal and state frameworks.

Isma, Aneeka's older sister, is also very important. Isma is a hijab-wearing academic who fights Islamophobia in the West. She is a good example of how gender, religion, and race can all be connected. *"You walk into a room and you're just a person," she says. She says, "I walk in and I'm a hijab"* (Shamsie, 2017, p. 72), which shows how people often see Muslim women as only their looks. Shamsie's women aren't just victims; they're thinkers, performers, and mourners who show strength in both public and private settings.

Shamsie utilizes violence in Karachi to think about gender and memory in her novel *Kartography* (2002). Raheen, the main female character, is smart and strong as she moves through male-dominated areas. You can tell she can challenge history, identity, and even male entitlement by the way she thinks: *"You think it's platitudes are so simple—boy saves girl—but have you ever thought about whether the girl wanted Alcide to save her?"* (Shamsie, 2002, p. 184). This self-reflection shows a feminist point of view that questions romantic and patriarchal ideas about women's dependence on men.

Mohsin Hamid's stories often have male main characters, but he challenges traditional masculinity by showing how weak it is emotionally and culturally. Changez, a Pakistani guy who went to Princeton, has a problem of identity and belonging in America after 9/11 in *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* (2007). His disappointment is linked to both world politics and his own relationships. After her ex-boyfriend dies, Erica, his lover, becomes emotionally inaccessible. Changez thinks, *"She was going into her own world, and I couldn't go with her"* (Hamid, 2007, p. 118). Here, gender roles are difficult. Erica doesn't want to be dependent on men like most women do, while Changez is shown to be fragile and emotionally unstable, which goes against the usual gender stereotypes.

Hamid's *Moth Smoke* (2000) likewise has a male main character named Daru who loses his job and becomes addicted to drugs. This is a sign of a broken masculine ideal in postcolonial Pakistan. Daru says, *"My father was a clerk; I had dreams."* *"Dreams don't pay rent," Hamid says* (2000, p. 76). His inability to represent patriarchal achievement shows that

he is anxious about his gender because of class and social expectations. Both novels take away the heroic traits that men usually have and show masculinity as unstable and troubled instead.

Moni Mohsin uses humor in *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* (2008) to criticize the inconsistencies of elite urban femininity in Lahore. Her main character, Butterfly, is a socialite who cares a lot about her looks, clothes, and reputation. But her overblown worries show how shallow and contradictory gender roles are among Pakistan's upper class. She says, "*Of course I believe in women's rights." That's why I let my maid go when she talked back: freedom has to have boundaries!*" (Mohsin, 2008, p. 43) This sarcastic comment makes fun of fake feminism and the way feminist language is turned into a product.

Butterfly doesn't actively fight against patriarchy, but Mohsin uses her to show how silly it is. The main character's constant contradictions—saying they are modern yet supporting class and gender oppression—show how patriarchy works even in places that say they are progressive. The novel makes it clear that privileged women can be both victims and actors of patriarchal reinforcing. In *Other Rooms, Other Wonders* (2009) by Daniyal Mueenuddin shows in a very clear way how social hierarchies affect gender roles. In the story "*Saleema*," the main character exploits her sexual power to find short-term stability. "*She knew that her body was the only thing that gave her a degree of power in the world of men*" (Mueenuddin, 2009, p. 97). Saleema's acts aren't idealized; they're depicted as a way to stay alive in a system where elite males have all the power and women are treated poorly.

Nawab's wife in "Nawabdin Electrician" is unnamed and mostly silent, which shows how working-class women are often left out of stories that focus on men. Mueenuddin's work illustrates that gender roles are not always the same for everyone. For example, rich women may discover strategies to deal with power, but poor women often face even more marginalization. Through comedy, Mohammed Hanif criticizes militaristic masculinity and institutional patriarchy in *A Case of Exploding Mangoes* (2008). His picture of General Zia's government shows how governmental surveillance, religious dogma, and fear perpetuate gender standards. "*Sir, she writes about her breasts,*" one of the military officers said to make fun of a female poet. *It's disgusting!* (Hanif, 2008, p. 104). This overreaction shows how weak masculinity is and how much it fears women being able to do what they want with their bodies.

Female characters don't take up as much space in the story, but they have a big effect. Even though she can't see, the First Lady knows how hypocritical the government is and discreetly changes the political conversation. Hanif also features a female journalist who writes articles criticizing the state while risking censorship. She is where boldness meets a very patriarchal system. His female characters don't follow standard roles by using resistance instead of love subplots.

4.3 Challenging or Reinforcing Patriarchy

Contemporary Pakistani English fiction plays a big role in criticizing, questioning, and sometimes even unwittingly supporting patriarchal norms. Authors examine social norms, gender hierarchies, and the voices of marginalized women via complex storytelling and a variety of characters. But in this complicated world of literature, the degree to which patriarchy is broken down or strengthened differs. Some writings are very feminist, while others use tradition, class, and national identity to gently show how patriarchal systems work.

The Reluctant Fundamentalist (2007) by Mohsin Hamid tells a complicated story from a male point of view, yet it is not clear how it treats women. Changez falls in love with Erica, an American woman. She is shown through a masculine lens, and her mental pain becomes a symbol of the West's lost innocence. "*I couldn't bring myself to be fully present,*" Erica admits. "*I had to be with him*" (Hamid, 2007, p. 100), her character becomes a symbol of a woman who is overwhelmed by memories and pain. Instead of being an independent person, Changez's story makes her into an emotional void. This picture quietly perpetuates patriarchal ideas about how weak women are. But Hamid also questions patriarchal masculinity. Changez's breakdown and leaving corporate America show that he doesn't believe in the stories of success that are based on capitalism and patriarchy. He says, "*I had become a servant of the American empire at considerable cost to myself*" (Hamid, 2007, p. 152), which shows that he was no longer playing a powerful male role.

Kamila Shamsie's *Home Fire* (2017) aggressively goes against patriarchy, especially through the character of Aneeka. Aneeka refuses to stay quiet in the face of state violence and patriarchal authority, even though she is reimagining the Antigone myth. She goes to Pakistan and demands justice after the British government refuses to bury her brother's body. She says, "*I'm going to find my brother's body and bury him with my own hands if I have to*" (Shamsie, 2017, p. 231), showing strength and moral commitment. Isma, her older sister, also goes against traditional gender stereotypes by coming to the UK to go to school and being a

Muslim lady who speaks truth to power. Shamsie's female protagonists fight against both Western and Islamic patriarchal structures, showing that they have power in situations where women are usually pushed to the side.

On the other hand, Shamsie's earlier novel *Salt and Saffron* (2000) uses family dynamics to gently criticize gender stereotypes. Aliya, the main character, thinks on how gender and class affect behavior. For example, "My mother thought girls should always speak in low tones." "Don't draw attention to yourself," she would say. "A good girl should never be heard before she's seen" (Shamsie, 2000, p. 56). Aliya later rejects this internalized patriarchy that is passed down from mother to daughter and tells her story with sarcastic resistance. So, even in a story that isn't really harsh, there are hints of criticism of patriarchy.

The Pakistani Bride (1983) by Bapsi Sidhwa is a more direct examines abuse against women in a patriarchal society. In a tribal context, Zaitoon, the main character, is forced into an arranged marriage and is treated badly by her husband. The tribe elder said, "She's your wife," which means that the tribal code of honor allows this kind of mistreatment. If she doesn't listen to you, hit her. "Kill her if you have to" (Sidhwa, 1983, p. 145). This scary remark sums up a patriarchal vision of the world in which women are property. But Zaitoon's brave flight into the mountains is a symbol of feminist resistance. Her voyage becomes a symbol of freedom from oppression at home and in society. Sidhwa's work is a strong criticism of patriarchy and shows how women may fight back by being independent.

In Sidhwa's *Ice-Candy-Man* (1988), the horrors of Partition are shown via a gendered lens. During conflicts between different groups, a beautiful Hindu nanny named Ayah is taken and forced into a brothel. The *Ice-Candy-Man's* possessive statement, "She is mine now, I have bought her" (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 202), shows how nationalism and patriarchy work together to turn women into objects. Ayah doesn't say much in the last section of the novel, but her suffering says a lot about violence against women during times of national unrest. Still, the women around her, like Lenny's Godmother, don't follow gendered silence by standing up for what is right and challenging male power.

The Diary of a Social Butterfly (2008) by Moni Mohsin uses humor to criticize the upper class in Lahore for how they act out their gender stereotypes and how they treat women. Butterfly, the narrator, is often doing performative feminism, repeating things like "I totally support working women" while making fun of them at the same time: "Honestly, I'd rather die than be caught dead wearing last season's shoes to a protest!" (Mohsin, 2008, p.

47). This satirical tone shows how even educated people have internalized patriarchal ideas about beauty, marriage, and how women should act. Butterfly isn't a typical feminist heroine, but Mohsin utilizes her silliness to show how contradictory Pakistani society is, where feminism is often turned into a business.

In Other Rooms, Other Wonders (2009) by Daniyal Mueenuddin makes the portrayal of gender more complicated by putting it in the context of socioeconomic relations. The narrator of "Nawabdin Electrician" points out that Nawab's wife is never named and doesn't say much, making her work seem invisible. In "Saleema," on the other hand, the main heroine is a servant who utilizes her sexuality as a way to get what she wants: *"She knew that her body was the only thing that gave her a degree of power in the world of men"* (Mueenuddin, 2009, p. 97). Saleema's limited authority shows that women's resistance is typically limited to the places that males provide in feudal and domestic hierarchies. Mueenuddin doesn't always fight against patriarchy; instead, he shows how it creeps into ordinary life, making the reader a part of its observation.

A Case of Exploding Mangoes (2008) by Mohammed Hanif criticizes the militaristic masculinity and institutional patriarchy of Zia-ul-Haq's dictatorship. Even though the novel is mostly about men, it also has women in it, including the blind First Lady and female journalists who quietly challenge authoritarian stories. A general anxiously explains why he censored a female poet's verses by saying, *"Sir, she writes about her breasts."* *This vignette makes fun of gender conventions. It's disgusting!* (Hanif, 2008, p. 104). This moment makes fun of how weak guys are and how scared they are of women's voices. Even if there aren't many female characters, Hanif's criticism of hypermasculinity and institutionalized sexism is nevertheless strong and clear.

A few patterns can be seen in all of these pieces. First, both men and women typically support patriarchal structures, and internalized sexism is a big part of this. Second, women resist in many ways, from open revolt (like Aneeka or Zaitoon) to more subtle ones like silence, irony, or memory. Third, gender often intersects with class, religion, and nationality, making power relations more complicated. Finally, satire is a strong literary weapon for showing how silly patriarchal thinking is.

4.4 Intersectionality and Identity

Intersectionality is a big part of Isma's character in Kamila Shamsie's *Home Fire* (2017). She is a British-Pakistani Muslim lady dealing with Islamophobia, gender

stereotypes, and familial devotion. She tells Eamonn, a politician's son, *"It's different for us... you walk into a room and you're just a person."* *"I walk in and I'm a hijab"* (Shamsie, 2017, p. 72). This comment shows how her Muslim identity, gender, and evident religion all come together to affect her life in a Western society full of bigotry and surveillance. The novel's many characters show diverse ways of being marginalized: Aneeka is a rebellious sister who fights against government control, while Parvaiz is a weak young guy who is drawn in by radical stories. Shamsie doesn't separate gender from ethnicity or religion; instead, she shows how they all work together to make up a person's identity.

In Mohsin Hamid's *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* (2007), the main character Changez likewise sees himself through different lenses: as a Pakistani man, a Muslim in America after 9/11, and a business elite who is having trouble fitting in. He discussed about how he was racially profiled in subtle but effective ways: *"I was verbally abused by strangers, and I was searched and forced to strip at airports so often that I started to wonder if I fit some profile"* (Hamid, 2007, p. 104). Here, Hamid shows how Changez's nationality, ethnicity, and religion all come together to change his place in American culture. His romantic relationship with Erica, a white American lady, even gets strained as she starts to see how "foreign" he is. Hamid looks at Western imperialism and how it affects men and women of different races via Changez's broken identity.

Bapsi Sidhwa's *Ice-Candy-Man* (1988) is set against the backdrop of Partition, when religion, ethnicity, gender, and colonial legacies all come together. During the religious turmoil of 1947, Ayah, a Hindu lady living in a mostly Muslim city, is kidnapped and sold into slavery. In a culture that is become more and more nationalistic, her attractiveness and openness become problems. Lenny, the narrator, says, *"She is no longer Ayah... She is someone else, someone he owns"* (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 200). Ayah's victimization is not just based on her gender, but also on her religion and ethnicity, which make her a target during disturbances. In the same way, Godmother, a strong Parsi lady, uses her social standing and moral authority to save women like Ayah. This shows how class and community can help people fight back. Sidhwa's work is a powerful reminder that we can't examine gender oppression without also looking at race, religion, and political violence.

Daniyal Mueenuddin's *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders* (2009) discussed on intersectionality by showing how class, gender, and the distance between rural and urban areas make men's and women's lives very different. In the story "Saleema," the main character, a domestic worker, exploits her sexuality to get some freedom, but she is still weak

in a society that is quite hierarchical. *She realized that her body was the only thing that gave her some influence over men* (Mueenuddin, 2009, p. 97). Saleema is treated differently by her male bosses and female mistresses because she is a working-class woman. Not only are the power dynamics in households based on gender, but they are also based on class. Even women who are further up on the socio-economic ladder help keep inequality going. Mueenuddin doesn't make her battles sound romantic; instead, he shows how capitalism and patriarchy work together to make her a transactional person.

Moni Mohsin's *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* (2008) is a satirical examines how gender and class interact in Pakistan's urban elite. The main character, Butterfly, represents a superficial, Westernized feminism that doesn't see class or privilege. She jokes, *"Of course I'm a free woman." I went to the gym without my driver!* (Mohsin, 2008, p. 23). Mohsin criticizes how bourgeois feminism can help keep patriarchal and classist systems in place. Butterfly's maids, cooks, and drivers are only seen as props in her social dramas, and her occasional support for "women's causes" is just for show. Mohsin uses humor to make the point that being aware of your gender is not enough; you also need to be aware of your class.

Going back to Shamsie, in *Kartography* (2002), the ethnic and political turmoil in Karachi serves as a backdrop for people who are having trouble figuring out who they are. Karim and Raheen are the main characters. They hail from wealthy households, but they had to deal with trauma that they received from their families' political ties during the 1971 Bangladesh war. *"My mother once told me that we are lucky not to belong because we belong everywhere," Raheen says. "That's just another way of saying we don't belong anywhere"* (Shamsie, 2002, p. 115). Shamsie uses this example to show how race and memory affect gendered experiences. The characters aren't poor or on the outside of society, but their hyphenated identities, which are based on class, race, and political history, make them feel like they don't know who they are.

A Case of Exploding Mangoes (2008) by Mohammed Hanif is mostly about military politics, but it also has critiques of gender and intersectionality. Even though she is blind, the First Lady is shown to be smart and politically savvy. It is clear that she is not being treated fairly in politics because of her gender and disabilities. More bluntly, Hanif criticizes how military masculinity makes people less emotionally open and more homophobic. The narrator says, *"They don't just fear women; they fear what women might bring out in them"* (Hanif, 2008, p. 131). This shows how gender, sexuality, and authoritarianism all come together to shape institutional authority in Pakistan. These literary depictions show that gender alone can't

explain how complicated identity is in Pakistan. Patriarchy works with religious minority like Parsis and Christians, ethnic minorities like Bengalis and Baloch, and differences in wealth and status to affect people's lives. These characters don't just have one problem; their problems come from systems of oppression that work together.

CHAPTER 5

DISCUSSION, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Discussion

In early works like Bapsi Sidhwa's *The Pakistani Bride* (1983) and *Ice-Candy-Man* (1988), female characters like Zaitoon and Ayah deal with violence against women in a patriarchal society, even though their voices are limited by cultural and social norms. Zaitoon's escape from a forced marriage, with her dupatta flying "like a banner" (Sidhwa, 1983, p. 161), is a clear example of overt opposition, even if it was dangerous and physical. Ayah's forced removal and objectification—"She is mine now, I have bought her" (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 202)—show how awful it was to treat women like things during Partition. Ayah doesn't have much power, but other women, including Godmother, fight against violence against women by threatening to send *Ice-Candy-Man* to jail for kidnapping a lady (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 195).

Writers like Kamila Shamsie and Mohsin Hamid show women having power in both political and personal areas nowadays. Aneeka says in *Home Fire* (2017), "I'm going to find my brother's body and bury him with my own hands if I have to" (Shamsie, 2017, p. 231). This shows her moral authority and commitment. Isma's decision to get an education and talk to Western officials, on the other hand, shows how global consciousness may impact an individual's choices. Shamsie's characters move resistance from private spaces (like escape and personal independence) to public spaces (like activism and state engagement).

In *The Diary of a Social Butterfly* (2008), Moni Mohsin uses comedy to criticize liberal superficiality by showing how affluent women talk about feminist values but act in ways that don't match what they say. The narrator's quick response—"I'd rather die than be caught dead wearing last season's shoes to a protest!" (Mohsin, 2008, p. 47)—shows how performative opposition is not always fair in urban areas with different classes. Men were generally shown as authoritarian or violent characters in early fiction, which helped to keep patriarchy going. But current literature shows that masculinity is not always strong. Changez in *The Reluctant Fundamentalist* (2007) says, "I had become a servant of the American empire at considerable cost to myself" (Hamid, 2007, p. 152). This shows that he doesn't agree with capitalism and imperial values. His identity dilemma, which is painfully clear at airports and in his relationship with Erica, shows how outside demands and disappointment make it harder for guys to be men.

In the same way, Mohammed Hanif makes fun of the military regime's machismo in *A Case of Exploding Mangoes* (2008). When a general bans a poem because it discussed about women's bodies, he says, "Sir, she writes about her breasts." It's disgusting! Hanif (2008, p. 104) points out the weakness that lies underlying authoritarian behavior. This disagreement goes against traditional ideas of male respect and shows a theater of fear, not power. On the other hand, early male characters, such as tribal elders in *The Pakistani Bride* and attackers in *Ice-Candy-Man*, typically have too much power. Modern writers are more likely to show their weaknesses and lies, which shows that they are questioning traditional gender roles.

Changing gender roles are also reflected in narrative tactics. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, Sidhwa adopts Lenny, a young Parsi girl, which gives the story an apparently unbiased, innocent voyeuristic view of violence against Ayah. The distance between the narrator and the victim makes it harder to hold people accountable, but it is clear that "all the men" are to blame for her disappearance (Sidhwa, 1988, p. 190). In contemporary works, first-person narratives like Changez in Hamid's novel and Butterfly in Mohsin's satire both support and question gender hierarchies. For example, Butterfly uses funny narration to deal with her shallow liberalism and invite criticism. Hamid's use of the letter format, which begins with "Dear American Reader," hints at how his main character will feel alone and shows how gender and identity are linked.

In *Home Fire*, Shamsie uses many points of view to give voice to men and women, Muslims and Westerners, traditional and governmental power. This polyphony breaks down the dominance of one perspective and shows how complicated things may be when they are

seen from many angles. Modern stories often talk about intersectional identity, whereas older ones mostly talk about gender and culture. Ayah, a Hindu woman living in a Muslim-majority area, and Zaitoon, an orphan from the city who moved to tribal life, show how gender and ethnicity/religion can overlap. But they don't often talk about class or global identity directly. Modern writing combines many different axes:

- In her novel *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders* (2009), Saleema says, "her body... [is] the only thing that gave her a degree of power in the world of men" (Mueenuddin, 2009, p. 97). As a woman from the working class, her sexuality is both a source of power and a source of abuse.
- In *Home Fire*, Isma deals with being a Muslim, being from the West, and dealing with gendered expectations. "I walk in and I'm a hijab" (Shamsie, 2017, p. 72).
- Changez and Erica show how race, gender, class, and nationality are all connected. After 9/11, the story includes themes of losing one's manly identity and feeling like an outsider in one's own culture.
- Moni Mohsin's *Butterfly* shows how affluent women keep patriarchy and classism alive by not letting domestic servants see them.

Satire is a very effective way to criticize gender. Hanif's caricature of military masculinity and Mohsin's parody of elite liberal feminism both make people feel bad about their gender and national identity. These works make readers question normal gender roles by showing how ridiculous patriarchy is, such when it censors women's bodies or makes social interactions shallow.

5.2 Conclusion

Female roles in Pakistani English fiction have altered greatly from early post-independence works to modern literary studies. *The Pakistani Bride* and *Ice-Candy-Man*, two older books by Bapsi Sidhwa, discussed how social standards, feudal honor, and religious identities repressed women. Resistance typically manifested as physical retreat or symbolic silence. These stories revealed how patriarchal tribal, colonial, and post-colonial communities repressed or obliterated women's voices. Even in these limited contexts, writers planted resistance, hinting at change. Feminist writers employed stories that evoked sympathy, fury, and discomfort to challenge patriarchal norms. However, modern gender fiction by Kamila Shamsie, Mohsin Hamid, Moni Mohsin, Daniyal Mueenuddin, and Mohammed Hanif has incorporated intersectionality, political action, comedy, and global perspectives. These pieces

demonstrate that class, religion, nationality, and globalization all shape a person's identity. Women are now leaders, activists, and symbolic challengers of state and cultural tyranny. Male characters' emotional flaws, identity difficulties, and violation of rules complicate what it means to be a man. This makes Pakistani English literature a vital venue to question gender hierarchies, critique national ideologies, and explore new strategies to resist in local and global contexts.

5.3 Recommendations

1. For students to understand how several identities impact their lives, English and literature departments in Pakistan and other countries should offer novels that explore gender from an intersectional perspective.
2. Increase opportunities for female, transgender, and minority authors in Pakistan to publish their work. Their gender identification and representation work challenges outdated norms.
3. Scholars studying Pakistani English fiction should apply feminist, queer, postcolonial, and sociological theories. This will show students how literature affects social transformation.
4. Research should compare South Asian authors with global writers on gender roles to see how cultural differences impact the struggle against patriarchy.
5. Further research should examine how individuals of all ages, geographies, and genders see gender roles in Pakistani fiction to better understand how literary tales impact real life.

REFERENCES

- Afzal-Khan, F. (1993). *Cultural Imperialism and the Indo-English Novel: Genre and Ideology in R.K. Narayan, Anita Desai, Kamala Markandaya, and Salman Rushdie*. Penn State University Press.
- Akhtar, S. (2015). Subaltern Resistance in Mohammed Hanif's *Our Lady of Alice Bhatti*. *Journal of Postcolonial Writing*, 51(5), 538–550.
- Alam, F. (2012). War, Memory, and Identity in Kamila Shamsie's *Burnt Shadows*. *Journal of Commonwealth Literature*, 47(2), 177–192.
- Ali, S. (2016). Gender and Conflict in Fatima Bhutto's *The Shadow of the Crescent Moon*. *Pakistan Journal of Women's Studies*, 23(1), 31–47.
- Anam, T. (2007). *A Golden Age*. Canongate Novels.
- Bama. (1992). *Karukku* (L. Holmstrom, Trans.). Macmillan.
- Beauvoir, S. de. (1949). *The Second Sex* (H. M. Parshley, Trans.). Vintage.
- Bhabha, H. K. (1994). *The Location of Culture*. Routledge.
- Boehmer, E. (2005). *Stories of Women: Gender and Narrative in the Postcolonial Nation*. Manchester University Press.
- Boehmer, E. (2009). *Empire, the National, and the Postcolonial, 1890–1920*. Oxford University Press.

- Butler, J. (1990). *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*. Routledge.
- Chatterjee, P. (1993). *The Nation and Its Fragments: Colonial and Postcolonial Histories*. Princeton University Press.
- Crenshaw, K. (1989). Demarginalizing the intersection of race and sex. *University of Chicago Legal Forum*, 1989(1), 139–167.
- Das, A. (2010). *Towards a Politics of the (Im)possible: The Body in Third World Feminisms*. Anthem Press.
- Gilbert, S. M., & Gubar, S. (1979). *The Madwoman in the Attic: The Woman Writer and the Nineteenth-Century Literary Imagination*. Yale University Press.
- Gohar, S. (2009). Post-9/11 Masculinities in Mohsin Hamid's *The Reluctant Fundamentalist*. *Pakistaniaat: A Journal of Pakistan Studies*, 1(2), 1–15.
- Hamid, M. (2000). *Moth Smoke*. Penguin.
- Hamid, M. (2007). *The Reluctant Fundamentalist*. Penguin Novels.
- Hanif, M. (2008). *A Case of Exploding Mangoes*. Jonathan Cape.
- Hanif, M. (2011). *Our Lady of Alice Bhatti*. Jonathan Cape.
- hooks, b. (1984). *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center*. South End Press.
- Jajja, M. A. (2013). Reconfiguring Masculinity in Pakistani Fiction. *Journal of Research in Gender Studies*, 3(1), 30–45.
- Jalal, A. (1991). *The Convenience of Subservience: Women and the State of Pakistan*. In K. Kandiyoti (Ed.), *Women, Islam and the State*. Palgrave Macmillan.
- Lahiri, J. (1999). *Interpreter of Maladies*. Houghton Mifflin.
- Mahmood, S. (2005). *Politics of Piety: The Islamic Revival and the Feminist Subject*. Princeton University Press.
- Minhas, S. (2007). *Tunnel Vision*. Roli Novels.
- Mohsin, M. (2008). *The Diary of a Social Butterfly*. Random House India.
- Mohsin, M. (2008). *The Diary of a Social Butterfly*. Random House India.
- Mueenuddin, D. (2009). *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders*. W. W. Norton & Company.

- Mukherjee, M. (1993). *Realism and Reality: The Novel and Society in India*. Oxford University Press.
- Pawar, U. (2008). *The Weave of My Life: A Dalit Woman's Memoirs* (M. Pandit, Trans.). Stree.
- Rahman, T. (1996). *Language and Politics in Pakistan*. Oxford University Press.
- Rao, R. R. (2003). *The Boyfriend*. Penguin India.
- Roy, A. (2017). *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*. Hamish Hamilton.
- Said, E. W. (1978). *Orientalism*. Pantheon Novels.
- Selvadurai, S. (1994). *Funny Boy*. McClelland & Stewart.
- Shaheed, F. (2002). Imagined Citizenship: Women, State and Politics in Pakistan. *Women Living Under Muslim Laws*.
- Shamsie, K. (2000). *Salt and Saffron*. Bloomsbury.
- Shamsie, K. (2002). *Kartography*. Bloomsbury.
- Shamsie, K. (2005). *Broken Verses*. Bloomsbury.
- Shamsie, K. (2009). *Burnt Shadows*. Bloomsbury.
- Shamsie, K. (2017). *Home Fire*. Riverhead Novels.
- Shariff, F. (2019). Islamophobia, Gender, and Agency in *Home Fire*. *Comparative Literature Studies*, 56(3), 450–472.
- Showalter, E. (1977). *A Literature of Their Own: British Women Novelists from Brontë to Lessing*. Princeton University Press.
- Sidhwa, B. (1983). *The Pakistani Bride*. Jonathan Cape.
- Sidhwa, B. (1988). *Cracking India*. Milkweed Editions.
- Sidhwa, B. (1988). *Ice-Candy-Man*. Heinemann.
- Spivak, G. C. (1988). Can the subaltern speak? In C. Nelson & L. Grossberg (Eds.), *Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture* (pp. 271–313). University of Illinois Press.
- Tharu, S., & Lalita, K. (Eds.). (1991). *Women Writing in India: 600 B.C. to the Present* (Vol. 1). Feminist Press.

Zubair, S. (2006). Feminist Discourse in Pakistani English Fiction. *South Asian Review*, 27(2), 122–139.

8% Overall Similarity

The combined total of all matches, including overlapping sources, for each database.

Filtered from the Report

- Bibliography
- Quoted Text
- Cited Text

Match Groups

- 96 Not Cited or Quoted 8%**
Matches with neither in-text citation nor quotation marks
- 0 Missing Quotations 0%**
Matches that are still very similar to source material
- 0 Missing Citation 0%**
Matches that have quotation marks, but no in-text citation
- 0 Cited and Quoted 0%**
Matches with in-text citation present, but no quotation marks

Top Sources

- 5% Internet sources
- 3% Publications
- 7% Submitted works (Student Papers)

Integrity Flags

0 Integrity Flags for Review

No suspicious text manipulations found.

Our system's algorithms look deeply at a document for any inconsistencies that would set it apart from a normal submission. If we notice something strange, we flag it for you to review.

A Flag is not necessarily an indicator of a problem. However, we'd recommend you focus your attention there for further review.

*% detected as AI

AI detection includes the possibility of false positives. Although some text in this submission is likely AI generated, scores below the 20% threshold are not surfaced because they have a higher likelihood of false positives.

Caution: Review required.

It is essential to understand the limitations of AI detection before making decisions about a student's work. We encourage you to learn more about Turnitin's AI detection capabilities before using the tool.

Disclaimer

Our AI writing assessment is designed to help educators identify text that might be prepared by a generative AI tool. Our AI writing assessment may not always be accurate (it may misidentify writing that is likely AI generated as AI generated and AI paraphrased or likely AI generated and AI paraphrased writing as only AI generated) so it should not be used as the sole basis for adverse actions against a student. It takes further scrutiny and human judgment in conjunction with an organization's application of its specific academic policies to determine whether any academic misconduct has occurred.

Frequently Asked Questions

How should I interpret Turnitin's AI writing percentage and false positives?

The percentage shown in the AI writing report is the amount of qualifying text within the submission that Turnitin's AI writing detection model determines was either likely AI-generated text from a large-language model or likely AI-generated text that was likely revised using an AI-paraphrase tool or word spinner.

False positives (incorrectly flagging human-written text as AI-generated) are a possibility in AI models.

AI detection scores under 20%, which we do not surface in new reports, have a higher likelihood of false positives. To reduce the likelihood of misinterpretation, no score or highlights are attributed and are indicated with an asterisk in the report (*%).

The AI writing percentage should not be the sole basis to determine whether misconduct has occurred. The reviewer/instructor should use the percentage as a means to start a formative conversation with their student and/or use it to examine the submitted assignment in accordance with their school's policies.

What does 'qualifying text' mean?

Our model only processes qualifying text in the form of long-form writing. Long-form writing means individual sentences contained in paragraphs that make up a longer piece of written work, such as an essay, a dissertation, or an article, etc. Qualifying text that has been determined to be likely AI-generated will be highlighted in cyan in the submission, and likely AI-generated and then likely AI-paraphrased will be highlighted purple.

Non-qualifying text, such as bullet points, annotated bibliographies, etc., will not be processed and can create disparity between the submission highlights and the percentage shown.

